

THE SEA ROAD

The King's Crusade – Module Two, Sea Road Variant

OVERVIEW

Run this module if the party chose the sea road at the end of Module One. If they chose the mountain road, use Module 2B instead — the two are mutually exclusive, and only one is ever played at a given table. The coalition fleet, three days out from Harrowmark, is scattered by a storm and driven onto the coast of Calanthe, a small independent island that answers to no crown. Its self-styled Warden, Ivor Thane, has spent years quietly ransoming and plundering ships wrecked on his coast, and several coalition vessels — including one carrying supplies the crusade cannot easily spare — have just become his newest opportunity. Core scenes run three and a half to four hours; Optional Content fills out the rest of a five-hour session and can be cut cleanly if the table is short on time.

THE SHAPE OF A SEA-LANE WAR

Play Calanthe as ordinary and opportunistic, not sinister. Warden Thane is not a monster and has no connection to Vale, to Elduvaine, or to anything the party will learn about later — he is a petty ruler who found a profitable position at a strait every southbound fleet has to pass, and has been quietly working it for longer than anyone in the coalition realized. This module's tension is not “what is this evil,” the way Elduvaine's will be. It is a smaller and in some ways harder question: what does a war for someone else's deliverance do to the small, uninvolved places it happens to pass through — and the party is about to decide the answer for one of them, in miniature, several modules before they have to decide it for a whole kingdom.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. The Storm	15–20 min	Fast and mostly narrative; ends with the party ashore on Calanthe.
2. Landfall	30–45 min	Wreckage, frightened survivors, and Thane's reputation, secondhand.
3. Thane's Hold	90–120 min	Negotiation, and combat if it comes to that. DC table and stat blocks below.
4. Calanthe's Fate	30–45 min	Loot, the island's future, and the road onward — Branch Ledger entry.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Ivor Thane is exactly what he appears to be: a minor lord who inherited a rock in the strait, worked out early that wrecked ships are worth more than the fishing rights ever were, and has spent a decade being quietly, unglamorously terrible to whoever the sea hands him. He is not secretly working for anyone. He is not a piece of a larger plot. He genuinely believes he is owed a toll for the use of his coastline, and he is genuinely surprised, every time, that anyone objects strenuously enough to do something about it.

DM Only: the point of this module is not Thane himself. It is the choice at the end of Scene 4 — what the coalition does with a small, real place it now has power over — and it should feel exactly as weighty as the party lets it. A table that wants to think hard about it should be able to; a table that wants to hand it to Sera Vosk and move on should be able to do that too, without being made to feel they missed something.

SCENE 1: THE STORM

Three days south of Harrowmark, with the coast long out of sight, the sky does what northern sailors say it always does when a crossing has gone too easily for too long.

The first anyone knows of it is the light going wrong — a green-grey dusk arriving hours early — and then the wind, which does not build so much as simply begin, all at once, as if a door somewhere had been thrown open. Somewhere off the bow, another ship's lantern swings wildly, then is gone.

Run this fast and mostly in narration. Let each PC make one relevant check if they want to help the crew (Strength (Athletics) to work the lines, Wisdom (Survival) to read the worst of it coming, an appropriate spell to calm water or clear fog) — success or failure barely matters mechanically and mostly colors how battered the party's own ship is when the storm breaks. What matters is the ending: the party's vessel, and at least one other coalition ship, are driven onto an unfamiliar coast as the wind finally drops. By morning, that coast has a name — Calanthe — offered by whichever sailor recognizes the headland first, along with a look that suggests the name means something unpleasant.

SCENE 2: LANDFALL

The beach the party makes for is already occupied — wreckage from a second coalition ship, planking and barrels and one overturned longboat, and a handful of soaked, shaken survivors doing what shipwrecked people do: counting who is missing.

A woman in a torn Auberitz quartermaster's coat looks up as the party approaches, calculates something visible behind her eyes, and does not waste time on relief. "If you've a ship that still floats, you're the first good news I've had all morning. If you don't — well. Welcome to Calanthe. Try not to look valuable."

This is Sera Vosk (see NPC Profiles). She has enough of the picture to be useful without knowing everything: Calanthe answers to a self-declared Warden named Ivor Thane, whose men have a habit of finding wrecks before anyone official does, and half of her own crew — including the ship's master, whom she will not stop mentioning by name — were taken up the cliff road toward his hold before dawn. She has been debating, alone, whether to go after them unarmed or wait for exactly the kind of help that just walked out of the surf.

Let the party spend some time here gathering what Calanthe's few frightened locals will say, if approached carefully: Thane holds captives for ransom, has for years, and nobody on the island loves him for it — but nobody has ever had a coalition fleet's worth of reasons to do anything about it either.

SCENE 3: THANE'S HOLD

The hold is less a fortress than a fortified manor — old stone, patched with newer and cheaper stone, flying a banner nobody recognizes over a gate that has clearly been rebuilt more than once. Thane receives visitors readily; ransom is, after all, his business, and armed strangers asking after his newest guests are simply customers who have not yet been told the price.

"Ah," says the man in the doorway, unhurried, a ledger genuinely under one arm. "More of the fleet that thought my strait was free water. I'm Ivor Thane, and I'm told this happens to be my island. Your people are safe, fed, and entirely available — for a reasonable consideration. I find negotiations go better before anyone has drawn a sword, so let's try that first, shall we?"

Calanthe itself is a fishing island of halflings and humans with a stubborn minority of everyone the sea has ever washed up, and it has been quietly resenting its Warden for a decade without ever being numerous enough to do anything about it. Let the party meet them before they meet Thane: a halfling harbour-wife who counts the coalition's ships aloud and does not like the number, a human net-mender who will say exactly nothing about the Warden and a great deal about the weather.

RUNNING THE SCENE

Thane will genuinely negotiate, and a table that wants to buy, threaten, or talk their way to the captives' release without a fight should be able to — he names an absurd price, but he is not attached to getting it, only to being paid something, and a successful Charisma (Persuasion or Intimidation) check against DC 16 gets his price down to something a coalition fleet can actually spare, or gets him to agree to release the captives in exchange for safe passage and a promise to leave his toll uncollected this once. He is not brave and is not interested in dying for a business model.

If the party refuses to pay, threatens him convincingly, is caught trying to free the captives by force, or simply attacks, it goes to violence — Thane's guards (use the Bandit stat block) fight to protect the hold and its stores, but break and flee the moment Thane himself surrenders, is captured, or is

reduced to half his hit points and makes his own morale call to cut losses. This should read as a real fight, not a formality, but it is not meant to be this module's hardest moment; see Scaling the Fight, below, for why.

SCALING THE FIGHT

Ivor Thane is the SRD Veteran (CR 3, 700 XP) renamed and reflavored, unmodified otherwise; his guards are SRD Bandits (CR 1/8, 25 XP each), both taken from the SRD unaltered. Run with Thane plus four Bandits — five total monsters, comfortably inside the 3–6 monster band, so no table's party size pushes the count across a multiplier boundary on its own.

Party size	Base XP	Multiplier	Adjusted XP	Medium threshold	Reads as
4	800	×2	1,600	2,000	Easy-Medium
5	800	×2	1,600	2,500	Easy-Medium, softer
6	800	×1.5	1,200	3,000	below Easy

This is deliberately not a Hard or Deadly fight, and the table below is not a problem to fix. Historically, Richard's taking of Cyprus was closer to a rout than a battle — Isaac Komnenos's forces were simply outmatched — and the module is built the same way on purpose: the real tension is Sera's crew as captives (see below), not whether the party can win. If a table wants more bite, the cleanest way to add it is to give Thane one Veteran-statted lieutenant instead of two of the Bandits, which raises the ceiling without changing the monster count or crossing a boundary. Do not simply add more Bandits to compensate for a party of six — crossing from 5 to 7 monsters jumps the multiplier band up a full step and can overcorrect badly, exactly the trap that scaling an encounter by headcount sets.

If it comes to a fight, the captives are in an outbuilding across the hold's yard, guarded by one Bandit who will threaten them the moment things turn against Thane — not out of malice, but as a bargaining chip. A PC who breaks off to reach them (a round's worth of movement and a DC 13 Athletics or Acrobatics check to cross the yard without being cut off) heads that off cleanly. A table that ignores the captives entirely should still free them once the fight ends — this is tension, not a fail state.

TIERED SKILL DCs

Easy 10, Moderate 13, Hard 16, matching the tiers used throughout this campaign.

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Help the crew through the worst of the storm	Athletics / Survival / relevant spell	13	Moderate
Recognize Calanthe's coastline before making landfall	Survival / Nature	13	Moderate
Get Calanthe's frightened locals talking about Thane	Persuasion / Insight	10	Easy
Talk Thane's price down without a fight	Persuasion / Intimidation	16	Hard
Cross the yard to reach the captives once a fight starts	Athletics / Acrobatics	13	Moderate
Read that Thane is bluffing about a price he won't die for	Insight	13	Moderate

STAT BLOCKS

Warden Ivor Thane

Medium humanoid (half-orc), any non-lawful alignment — SRD Veteran, renamed

Armor Class: 17 (splint armor)

Hit Points: 58 (9d8 + 18)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills: Athletics +5, Perception +2

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Common

Challenge: 3 (700 XP)

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Thane makes two longsword attacks. If he has a shortsword drawn, he can also make a shortsword attack.

Longsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (1d8 + 3) slashing damage, or 8 (1d10 + 3) slashing damage if used with two hands.

Shortsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage.

Heavy Crossbow. Ranged Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, range 100/400 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d10 + 1) piercing damage.

Thane's Guard

Medium humanoid (any race), any non-lawful alignment — SRD Bandit, unmodified

Armor Class: 12 (leather armor)

Hit Points: 11 (2d8 + 2)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

Senses: passive Perception 10

Languages: Common

Challenge: 1/8 (25 XP)

ACTIONS

Scimitar. Melee Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 4 (1d6 + 1) slashing damage.

Light Crossbow. Ranged Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, range 80/320 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d8 + 1) piercing damage.

SCENE 4: CALANTHE'S FATE

However Thane's hold was settled — paid off, talked down, or fought — the captives are freed, the fleet's missing stores are recovered from his cellars (along with a fair amount that is unmistakably not the coalition's, taken from other ships over other years), and the party is, whether they sought it or not, the reason a small independent island now has no one clearly in charge of it.

Sera finds the party before anyone else does, already counting crates. "There's enough here to make good the losses and then some," she says. "That's the easy part. The island's the hard part. Someone's going to have to decide what happens to it, and I'd rather it wasn't me."

Let the party decide Calanthe's fate. A coalition garrison secures the strait for the rest of the crusade's shipping, at the cost of putting an armed foreign power in charge of people who did not ask for one. Leaving Thane's household to govern itself, under new terms and a promise of no further tolls, costs the coalition a secure waypoint it may want later. A table can also split the difference — a light garrison with a local council retaining real authority — if they think to propose it; do not offer it as a third option unprompted.

DM Only: record this choice in the DM Reference Guide as its own Branch Ledger entry, separate from the road choice. It is a small-scale rehearsal of the campaign's largest question — what a liberator owes the place it liberates — and it is worth revisiting, briefly, whenever the party's coalition allies discuss what Elduvaine should become after the war. Do not force the parallel; if the table draws it themselves, that is the module working as intended.

The fleet resupplies, repairs what the storm damaged, and continues south within the day. Hand off directly to Module 5 for the approach to Vindana, where the mountain road's own losses — including the second king's — catch up with the party as news from the road not taken.

PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

The Breaking Ship is how the storm is run rather than more of it. The Moved Light expands the business at Thane's hold and adds perhaps twenty minutes, most of which the party will spend arguing with each other.

THE PUZZLE: THE MOVED LIGHT

Every sailor in the coalition fleet believes Ivor Thane moved a light and wrecked them deliberately. Half of Calanthe believes it too. The party can settle it, and the answer is more interesting than either side wants.

Four pieces of evidence, available to anyone who looks:

- **The Ossary light.** A stone tower on the headland, lit nightly, and it was lit that night — six people will swear to it. Its lamp burns four pints of oil in a night. The night of the storm it burned four pints. It was not moved and it was not doused.
- **The sightline.** From the deck of a ship on the approach, the Ossary light and the harbour light line up when you are safely in the channel. A DC 13 Intelligence (Investigation) check standing on the headland, or any sailor asked the right question, establishes this.

- **The harbour light.** Lit late that night. Two hours late. The keeper says he was ill; his neighbour says he was drinking; both are true and neither is the point.
- **The salvage log.** Thane's boats were in the water within forty minutes of the first ship striking. Forty minutes, at night, in that weather, is not a response. It is a readiness.

Put together: nobody moved a light. The harbour light was late, the sightline therefore did not exist, and three ships ran onto the shoals in the dark because of a lamp-keeper's bad night. Thane did not cause the wreck. Thane knew the harbour light was unreliable, had known for years, had never once fixed it or reported it, and had his boats crewed and waiting before the first hull touched.

DM Only: this is the module's best scene and it depends on the party being allowed to reach a conclusion the fleet will not like. Thane is not a wrecker and cannot be hanged as one; the evidence exonerates him of the thing everybody wants him hanged for and convicts him of something with no name and no penalty. If the party takes the truth to the coalition, they are taking away a justification eight thousand angry sailors were relying on. If they sit on it, they are letting a man hang for the wrong crime. Both are real. Neither is correct.

SET PIECE: THE BREAKING SHIP

Run the storm as a sequence of concrete problems on a deck that is coming apart, not as a montage. Three rounds per phase, real initiative, and the ship losing something in each one.

"The mast goes first, and it does not fall — it folds, forward and down, and takes the forestay and eleven feet of rail with it, and the noise it makes is not a crack but a long tearing groan you feel in your teeth. Then the ship comes off the top of a wave and does not come down where the sea is."

Phase One: The Rigging. The mainmast is down across the deck and the shrouds are still attached, which means the wreckage is being dragged and is pulling the bow round into the sea. Cutting it free is DC 15 Strength (Athletics) with an axe, three successes needed, and anyone working the rail makes a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw each round or goes over.

Phase Two: The Hold. Four feet of water and climbing, and the siege train's draught horses are down there. A character who goes below is in the dark, in water, with panicking animals. Getting them up is DC 14 Wisdom (Animal Handling); the alternative is closing the hatch, which everybody aboard will understand and nobody will forget.

Phase Three: The Shoals. The ship strikes. Everyone aboard makes a DC 12 Strength saving throw or is thrown twenty feet and takes 2d6 bludgeoning damage. From here it is swimming, and the swim is DC 13 Athletics, three successes, with Thane's boats arriving somewhere in the middle of it and the party watching them choose who to pick up first.

DM Only: nobody in the party should die here and the scene should feel like they might. Use the horses. A party that saves the draught team keeps the siege train on schedule and will find out in Module Six exactly what that was worth, and a party that closes the hatch will find that out

too, from an Auberitz engineer who is not accusing them of anything.

NPC PROFILES

SERA VOSK

An Auberitz-born rock gnome and a career quartermaster, more practical than the situation strictly allows. Speech: fast, dry, allergic to wasted words — she will assess a room's exits before its people, and say so if asked. Not a fighter by training, but not helpless either; she has spent a career keeping ships supplied through worse than one bad morning.

Open thread: Sera is a natural recurring contact for logistics and information for the rest of the campaign — a DM can bring her back at Vindana, or later, as the person who always seems to know where the supplies actually are. She has no stake in Calanthe's fate beyond wanting the crates loaded and the fleet moving, and will say so plainly if the party asks her opinion on the island's future.

WARDEN IVOR THANE

A half-orc going comfortably to seed, and comfortable rather than menacing with it; he carries a ledger more often than a weapon. Speech: unhurried, transactional, genuinely puzzled by moral objections to what he considers a straightforward toll on a strait he happens to control. Not cruel for its own sake — captives are an asset, and a damaged asset is worth less.

Open thread: if he survives — captured, exiled, or simply talked out of his hold — Thane is exactly the kind of small, self-interested operator who resurfaces later in a campaign, working for whoever will have him. A DM looking for a low-stakes recurring rogue later in the crusade has him available.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

WHAT THE LOCALS REMEMBER

Before or after Thane's hold, let the party spend some time among Calanthe's ordinary people — fisherfolk, a handful of farms, an old woman who remembers a Warden before Thane and says the position used to mean something. Play this for texture and moral weight rather than plot: nobody here asked for a war to wash up on their coast, and their opinions about what should happen next are worth hearing even though the party is not obligated to follow them.

THE SECOND SHIP

If the table wants more to do before Thane's hold, a third coalition vessel can be found wrecked on a further stretch of coast, its survivors already having made their own uneasy peace with a Calanthe fishing village. A short scene of relief and minor logistics — no combat required — that adds texture without adding a beat the module needs.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **How Thane's hold is settled.** Paid off, talked down, or fought — track which. A talked-down or paid-off resolution leaves Thane in a position to resurface later (see his NPC profile); a fight that kills or captures him removes that thread but earns Calanthe's locals more open gratitude in the near term.
- **Calanthe's fate.** Garrisoned by the coalition, left independent under new terms, or a hybrid the table proposes — record this as its own Branch Ledger entry, separate from the road choice, and note it as the campaign's first small-scale rehearsal of what a liberator owes the place it liberates.

LOOT

- **The recovered stores.** Enough of the fleet's lost supplies, plus a portion of Thane's accumulated plunder, to be a genuine funding boost for the crusade — play this narratively as the coalition arriving at Vindana somewhat better supplied than it otherwise would have, rather than a large individual coin payout at 5th level.
- **Thane's ledger.** A genuinely useful item: years of records of ships, cargoes, and (if he is captured or cooperative) contacts along the southern sea-lanes. A DM can use it to justify a Diverging Paths hook or a piece of information the party needs later without it feeling handed to them.
- **A bag of holding.** Bottom of Thane's stores, taken off a wreck years ago, and by a distance the most valuable thing on Calanthe — he has been using it to store rope. Sera Vosk will notice what it is roughly one second before anybody else does and will not pretend otherwise.
- **A signet ring.** Thane's own, if he is defeated or surrenders it as part of a bargain. Non-magical, but recognizable to anyone in the region who has dealt with Calanthe's toll — a DM may let it open doors, or close them, wherever that is true.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*